A.J. MERLINO, DMA

Academic Executive Curriculum Vitae

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Academic Executive Profile

Academic and arts executive with a Doctor of Musical Arts and more than 15 years of leadership across fine arts, music education, faculty development, student success, and creative practice. Record of strategic planning, resource stewardship, curriculum and program development, grant development, accreditation support, and community partnership building. Collaborative leader experienced in college-wide change and committed to teaching, scholarship, performance, creative activity, and public engagement.

Education and Professional Credentials

- **Doctor of Musical Arts:** University of Nevada, Las Vegas, 2014. (Dissertation: **The Percussionist Bodybuilder: Optimizing Performance Through Exercise and Nutrition).**
- **Master of Music:** University of Nevada, Las Vegas, 2012.
- **Bachelor of Arts in Music:** Kutztown University of Pennsylvania, 2010.
- **Business in the Metaverse Economy Certificate:** Wharton Executive Education, 2023.
- **Avid Certification:** Pro Tools Specialist and Media Composer Specialist, 2023.
- **Experiential Education Academy:** Society for Experiential Education, 2021.
- **Certified ScrumMaster:** Scrum Alliance, 2021.

Academic Administrative Experience

Associate Dean and Director for Creative Impact Programs, School of Business

Western Governors University, Salt Lake City, UT (Remote) | Sep 2025 - Present

- Lead the Creative Impact Portfolio, including BS User Experience Design, BS Communications, and MS in Human Centered Design, with program strategy, curriculum development, faculty and staff leadership, enrollment performance, and student success responsibility for a $20M+ portfolio.
- Develop personalized, competency-based programs that connect discipline-specific instruction, applied assessments, and work-based learning so students can demonstrate mastery in professional contexts.
- Lead industry collaboration, including a college-wide Adobe partnership; industry experts in residence; integration of workforce credentials; faculty development; and practitioner engagement.
- Lead continuous quality improvement reviews that use enrollment, early-course pacing, completion, retention, and student-feedback data to identify barriers; assign changes to owners and due dates; and assess results against baselines and targets.
- Supported NWCCU and ACBSP accreditation compliance for programs and curricula.

Associate Dean, School of Business, Technology and Industry
Interim Department Chair, Communications, Humanities and Arts

Harrisburg Area Community College, Harrisburg, PA | Feb 2025 - Sep 2025

- Oversaw 35+ programs across business, entrepreneurship, hospitality, IT, skilled trades, engineering, architecture, communications, humanities, and arts; led faculty hiring and development, program innovation, strategic planning, budget management, and external partnerships.
- Represented the school in college-wide governance and regional economic-development partnerships; directed enrollment initiatives, external funding pursuits, and industry collaborations.
- Provided academic leadership through faculty unionization and a presidential transition; supervised 90+ tenure-track, full-time, and adjunct faculty across five campuses and online.
- Led change management, faculty recruitment and evaluation, curriculum assessment, and student advising while sustaining program continuity and instructional excellence.
- Supported MSCHE and NASAD accreditation compliance for programs, curricula, and facilities.

Executive Director, Learning Innovation and Workforce Solutions

Thinking Through AI, Remote | Dec 2024 - Sep 2025

- Directed AI-powered workforce-learning initiatives across 300+ cross-sector partners, overseeing program development, strategic partnerships, and operations.

- Co-designed ThinkingThrough.AI and Readocracy, platforms for personalized learning, flexible competency verification, and employer-connected credentials aligned to BLS and Lightcast skills data.
- Secured $500K+ in grant and public funding for technology-sector credentials and apprenticeships, including a $399,896 Pennsylvania Department of Labor and Industry award.
- Led product and workforce implementation for Thinking Through AI, built on Readocracy infrastructure recognized by Mozilla's Fix The Internet Open Lab, SXSW, IBM, Canada's Digital News Innovation Challenge, and The Globe and Mail's Lab351.

Associate Vice President, Student Professional Development and Experiential Learning
Harrisburg University of Science and Technology, Harrisburg, PA | Aug 2022 - Nov 2024

- Directed Career Services and Experiential Learning across a multi-campus, multi-modal institution; managed a $400K budget and supervised staff.
- Built micro-internship, residency, and apprenticeship pathways with 3,000+ employer partners, supporting hands-on learning for undergraduate and graduate students and 94% positive postgraduate outcomes within six months of graduation.
- Established the university as a registered apprenticeship sponsor and related technical instruction provider; developed $800K+ in proposed work and grant funding and revenue-generating education-technology partnerships.

Associate Professor, Business and Live Entertainment
Program Lead, Learning Technology and Media Systems

- Led the Learning Technology and Media Systems graduate program and developed the Entertainment Technology Certificate with Avid credentials and partnerships with TAIT, Rock Lititz, and Clair Global.

Associate Dean, Student Professional Development and Experiential Learning (2019 - 2022)
Albright College, Reading, PA | 2015 - 2022

- Led seven direct reports and 12 staff across experiential learning, career development, student employment, and the 13th Street Educational Partnership; managed a $700K annual budget.
- Increased positive postgraduate outcomes from 84% to 91%, reached a 100% internship-acquisition rate within four years, and facilitated 4,000+ hands-on learning opportunities.
- Directed professional training, credit for prior learning, and ESL education for adult learners from underserved communities; implemented real-time data-sharing systems for stakeholder decision-making.

Director, Music Industry Studies; Music Department Chair; Assistant Professor (2015 - 2022)

- Led the Music Department, supervising eight full-time and 12 adjunct faculty and managing an $800K departmental budget.
- Developed and launched the Music Industry Studies major, growing enrollment from 12 to 75 students in fewer than five years through applied learning, recruitment, experiential marketing, studio work, and internships.
- Built partnerships with Atlantic Records, Warner Music Group, Universal Music Publishing, ASM Global, and Live Nation; created the annual Music Business Forum for students and working professionals.

Additional Academic and Arts Appointments

Founder, President, and Music Director
Reading Samba School, Reading, PA | Jan 2013 - Dec 2019

- Founded and managed a 501(c)(3) community arts organization providing music education and public performance; grew the organization to 50+ regular members and five staff.
- Collaborated with Reading Musical Foundation and Berks Arts Council on music education workshops and grant-supported community programming.

Instructor of Music and Percussion Studio Director
Kutztown University of Pennsylvania, Kutztown, PA | Aug 2013 - Dec 2016

- Taught percussion lessons, ensembles, music business, and chamber music; grew the percussion studio from 18 to 30 majors within two years.

Graduate Assistant in Percussion
University of Nevada, Las Vegas, Las Vegas, NV | Aug 2010 - Aug 2013

- Instructed History of Rock and Roll, Steel Band, Percussion Ensemble, and Marimba Band.

Experience Designer, Project Manager, and Music Director
Hayden Productions, BESTAgency, and Entertainment Plus Productions, Las Vegas, NV | Jan 2011 - Dec 2014

- Planned and managed large-scale events for high-profile clients at Las Vegas venues and collaborated with Cirque du Soleil on experiential marketing campaigns.

Selected Teaching Experience

- **Harrisburg University:** Audio Engineering I and II; Pro Tools for Game Audio; Video Editing: Media Composer I and II; Experiential Learning Seminar 300.
- **Albright College:** Music Business; Demo to Distribution; Artist and Repertoire; Entrepreneurship; Event Promotion; Entertainment Law and Ethics; Talent Management; Entertainment Marketing; First-Year Seminar; Senior Seminar; Capstone; Internship; Percussion Lessons.
- **Kutztown University:** Fundamentals of Music Business; Concert Percussion Ensemble; World Music Ensemble; Percussion Lessons.
- **University of Nevada, Las Vegas:** History of Rock and Roll; Percussion Ensemble; Steel Band; Marimba Band.

Grants Awards and Resource Development

- **$614,917 | Awarded 2025:** Principal Investigator. SIP Pathways to Smart Recovery, U.S. Department of Education Strengthening Institutions Program award to Harrisburg University.
- **$399,896 | Awarded 2025:** Grant development lead. SCPa Cyber Defenders Apprenticeship and Pre-Apprenticeship, Pennsylvania Department of Labor and Industry award to SCPa Works.
- **$750,000 | Awarded 2024:** Grant development lead. Empowering Greenhouse Resiliency with an Optimized Workforce (E-GROW), USDA NIFA award.
- **$45,000 | Awarded 2024:** Contributor. Digital Literacy for Justice-Impacted Youth, South Central Pennsylvania Workforce Development Board award.
- **$24,750 | Awarded 2024:** Contributor. Readocracy for Workforce Development, TechConnect South Central PA award.
- **$20,000 | Awarded 2023:** Contributor. Presidential Research Grant, Harrisburg University.
- **$74,399 | Awarded 2022:** Contributor. Robert Noyce Teacher Scholarship Program, National Science Foundation.
- **$25,000 | Awarded 2022:** Contributor. Albright-Drexel Partnership Planning Grant, Berks Alliance.
- **$25,000 annually | Awarded 2019-2021:** Contributor. 13th Street Partnership Support Grant, Wyomissing Foundation.
- **$25,000 | Awarded 2021:** Contributor. United Way grant supporting the 13th Street Educational Partnership.
- **$5,000 annually | Awarded 2019-2021:** Contributor. Experiential Learning Support Grant, Enterprise Holdings Foundation.
- **$1,106 | Awarded 2017-2018:** Recipient. Pennsylvania Partners in the Arts grant, Reading Samba School.

Publications and Presentations

Selected Presentations

- **Make Learning Anywhere Count** | Pennsylvania Workforce Development Association Youth Summit, 2025
- **Make Learning Anywhere Count** | Pennsylvania Educational Technology Expo and Conference, 2025
- **Creating an Experiential Learning Ecosystem at a Global Scale** | The Career Leadership Collective and Society for Experiential Education, 2023
- **Using Project Management Principles to Create Agile Learning Communities** | American Conference of Academic Deans, 2023
- **National Association for Music Education Regional Conference Presentation** | 2021

Selected Publications

- **The Future of Workforce Development: Embracing AI** | Digital First Magazine, 2024
- **From Tradition to Transformation: Rethinking Career Services in Higher Education** | Higher Ed Digest, 2024
- **Preparing for the Real World: How Learn-Work-Earn Programs Are Changing the Face of Higher Education** | Higher Ed Digest, 2023
- **Utilizing Ishikawa Diagrams for Effective Project Management in Higher Education** | Higher Ed Digest, 2023

- **Using Project Management Principles to Develop Academic Learning Communities** | Higher Ed Digest, 2022

Selected Scholarly and Creative Publications

- **Yakshi** | Self-published, 2019
- **The Music Business Handbook** | Sage Publishing; reviewer, 2017
- **Stormy Suite** | A Jones to Remember; contributing composer and lyricist, 2017
- **Mozambique Math** | Self-published; composer, 2017
- **For Sergio** | Self-published; composer, 2016
- **Maracatu** | Self-published; composer, 2016
- **Summer Songo** | Self-published; composer, 2016
- **The History and Development of the Cajon** | Self-published, 2014

Creative Scholarship

Compositions, Commissions, and Premieres

- Hosted, composed, promoted, and performed in Sound Masses and Wine Glasses, an original music, performance, and glass-art event, 2019.
- Commissioned work from Casey Cangelosi, Pius Cheung, Igor Silva, and Justin Raines; premiered works for multi-percussion, marimba, and cimbalom by David T. Little, Virko Bailey, Jim Barnes, Scott Steele, Eric Whitacre, and Michael Daugherty.
- Supernova IIb: Bruno Lo Bianco, soloist; CETC, 2019.

Selected Recordings

- **Stranger Heads Prevail:** Thank You Scientist, percussionist; Billboard No. 14 Top Rock Album and Billboard 200 No. 193, 2016.
- **The Dreams That Stuff Are Made Of:** Karmic Juggernaut, percussionist; Independent Music Award Album of the Year, Funk/Fusion, 2018.
- **Terraformer:** Thank You Scientist, percussionist; iTunes No. 8 Alternative Rock Album and No. 47 Top Album, 2019.
- **Ladies and Gentlemen Remember Jones:** Remember Jones, percussionist; Kickstarter-funded recording, 2016.
- **We Used to Cut the Grass #1:** We Used to Cut the Grass, percussionist.
- **We Used to Cut the Grass #2:** We Used to Cut the Grass, percussionist.
- **Rebels in Paris:** Vox Ama Deus Ensemble and Valentin Radu, soloist and section percussion.
- **Tranquilizer:** Remember Jones, percussionist, writer, and arranger.

Selected Performances and International Engagement

- **2019:** Tambor Fantasma, Teatro Colón, Buenos Aires, Argentina; Acoustic Spill, solo performance and masterclass, Universidad del Salvador, Buenos Aires; Sound Masses, solo performance, Reading, Pennsylvania; Thank You Scientist album premiere, White Eagle Hall, Jersey City, New Jersey.
- **2017:** Remember Jones with Darlene Love, Red Bank, New Jersey; Thank You Scientist with Coheed and Cambria, Terminal 5, New York; soloist, Susquehannock Day of Percussion, Glen Rock, Pennsylvania.
- **2014-2012:** University of Adelaide Percussion Festival, presenter and performer, Adelaide, Australia, 2014; Cirque du Soleil One Night for One Drop, percussionist, Bellagio Las Vegas, 2013; International Percussion Festival, percussionist and instructor, Córdoba, Argentina, 2012; Billboard Music Awards, percussionist for Cee Lo Green, Las Vegas, 2012.
- **2009-2011:** Rebels in Paris, cimbalom soloist with Vox Ama Deus Ensemble, Philadelphia, 2011; Moravian Wind Symphony, cimbalom soloist and premiere performer, 2011; Reading Symphony Orchestra, cimbalom soloist, 2009; IPEW, percussionist, Bjelovar, Croatia, 2009.

Professional and Academic Service

National, Regional, and Community Service

- **National Endowment for the Arts:** Panelist, Presenting and Multidisciplinary Works review panel, 2026.
- **Recycle Bicycle Harrisburg:** Board Member, 2023-Present.
- **American Marketing Association of Central PA:** Board Member and Chair, Collegiate Committee, 2023-Present; Events and Programming Committee, 2022-2024.
- **Technology Council of Central Pennsylvania:** Education Committee, 2024-Present.
- **SCPa Works:** Talent, Supply, and Diversity Committee and Membership Committee, 2022-Present.

- **PaArtners and Berks JazzFest:** Educational Planning Committee, PaArtners, Pennsylvania Council on the Arts, 2017-2022; Education Committee, Berks JazzFest, 2015-2022.
- **Additional community service:** Miller Center Advisory Council, Reading Area Community College, 2021; Northeast Youth Development Taskforce, 2019-2022.

Institutional Service

- **Western Governors University:** General Education Committee and Accreditation Work Group, 2025-Present.
- **Harrisburg University:** Extended Reality Taskforce, 2022-2024; Experiential Learning Seminar Working Group, 2022-2024; Institutional Effectiveness Technology Infrastructure Subcommittee, 2022-2023.
- **Albright College:** Assessment Committee, 2021-2022; Library Vision Team, 2020-2022; Graduate Advisory Committee, 2019-2022; Empowering Albright Voices Committee, 2021-2022; Supporting Student Success Working Group co-lead, 2019; NCAA Faculty Athletics Representative and Trustee Representative for Advancement, Arts, and Humanities, 2019-2020.
- **Academic leadership and search service:** Institutional Representative for Rhodes and Marshall Scholarships, 2021; Chair, Applied Commercial Music Search Committee, 2019; Chair, Music Theory and Technology Search Committee, 2019.

Honors and Recognition

- **2025:** Educator of Note, Central Pennsylvania Music Hall of Fame.
- **2024:** Campus Sustainability Champion, Pennsylvania Environmental Resource Consortium.
- **2021-2022:** Recognition for Best Colleges for Career Development, Colleges of Distinction.
- **2017, 2018, 2020, 2022, 2023:** Quarterfinalist, Music Educator Award, The Recording Academy and GRAMMY Museum.

Additional Creative and Professional Engagement

Adjudication

- **Music and performance adjudication:** ENKOR International Competition, 2017-2022; Conrad Weiser Jazz Festival, 2019-2022; Muhlenberg Jazz Festival, 2019-2022; Governor Mifflin Jazz Festival, 2019-2022; Oley Valley Jazz Festival, 2016-2019; Reading Musical Foundation Scholarship Audition, 2016-2019.

Selected Community Performances and Arts Events

- **2016-2017:** Reading Samba School at Sister March, Reading, Pennsylvania, 2017; Reading Samba School with Low Cut Connie, Reading Bandshell, 2016; Reading Samba School at Arts on the Ave, Reading, 2016; Reading Samba School at Reading Salsa Festival, 2016; Reading Samba School at Lancaster Hispanic Festival, 2016; Reading Samba School Olympic Kickoff, Brooklyn, New York, 2016.
- **2016-2019:** Live Scoring of Nosferatu, host and percussionist, 2021; Sound Masses and Wine Glasses Gala, music director, host, composer, and percussionist, 2019; Albright College Music Business Forum, host and coordinator, 2016-2021.

Student Advising, Recruitment, and Mentoring

- **Academic advising:** Institutional Representative for Rhodes and Marshall Scholarships, 2021; senior-thesis reader and adviser; Music Affinity House adviser, 2016-2021; Lion Records coordinator, 2019-2021; Lion Enterprises student-organization adviser, 2016-2018.
- **Recruitment and public education:** Music-program outreach through Berks Catholic Career Day, Albright College open houses and accepted-students events, Pennsylvania Music Educators Conference, Pennsylvania Liberal Arts Tour, and regional high-school recruiting, 2016-2022.